

Weekly 5

Hazel Lutz

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Weekly Progress (5 points)

1. Committing to QCA as my research method – given the number of cases it looks like I’ll have per category (uncommitted, since I’m still tailoring the start year of my study), it seems like a very reasonable research method that provides interesting results. The primary textbook I’m using for this is Patrick A. Mello’s *Qualitative Comparative Analysis: An Introduction to Research Design and Application*, though I’ve consulted some other resources (this is just a good comprehensive introduction). I think I’ll find some example versions for political science to learn from past cases. It also lets you have some pretty unique insights!
2. Made the switch to Correlates of War as my conflict dataset – having some supplemental information from UCDP may end up being useful, so I’ll keep my pruned version of that dataset in case it becomes useful (and the code for deriving it). It comes down to what information I wish I had on my overall dataset and actually getting there. I think I’m going to stick with R up until the actual analysis as well.
3. Performed some EDA on the cases I have (particularly comparing between the internationalized and non-internationalized cases). I may end up having issues with the classification that COW has done already for that, but it seems to be a reasonable enough? I’m still going to do some digging on this if I can. Quoth the 4.0 codebook, “[i]ntra-state wars are classified as ‘internationalized’ when an outside state or states intervenes in the war. The war remains classified as “internationalized” as long as the intervener does not take over the bulk of the fighting from one of the initial parties” (p. 4).
4. Started prepping to merge my datasets into one comprehensive one with all the data I need to get going with the quantitative analysis. This primarily requires categorizing each of these into categories based on whether they adequately measure what I’m looking for. Will have a full merge by early next week so I can get started with the QCA.
5. Researched QCA software – I have a few options, which are a Python package (which I did a little looking into but seems individually-maintained, which is not ideal), an R package, which has extensive documentation behind the history and design and comparison to other softwares, and one with a GUI run on who-knows-what. While the latter two seem very usable, I’ll probably stick with the R package for Linux compatibility (though try out the one with the GUI – I find that most social science people prefer those kinds of softwares and it would be nice to be familiar with it).

Challenges (3 points)

1. I have to go through some somewhat menial work to merge all my datasets into one to work with – this requires turning my proxy measures for various forms of legitimacy of institutions and belief in forms of government and access to resources into one solid category, quantified using averages over all those measures (provided that seems to be adequate with the bit of analysis I do beforehand). Keeping documentation on these things is very important for the legitimacy of my study. Though I’m not yet committing to these changes – my EDA and analysis have all been impromptu between datasets rather than within just one – it should still be fine.

2. This is the first time I've been using the Correlates of War dataset over UCDP – consequently, I'm having to check the classification and derivation of some of their statistics, and also their information doesn't stretch as far as UCDP does. I'll probably end up using information from both – COW primarily for civil war classification and UCDP for information about it – but that may end up getting messy. Either way, it's another layer of complexity that would be better avoided. Very soon, however, I should have one singular dataset with all the information I could ever possibly want! Looking forward to no more problems there. It's just been quite a bit of cross-referencing and caution. Sigh.
3. Not that it's been particularly difficult, but teaching myself a new methodology is something that is maybe a little confusing? Figuring out how to apply the theory and whatnot. Some of the softwares I've seen are actually helping to clear up the workflow. Hopefully should be in a good position for that by next week.

Code Commits (2 points)

1. Changed dataset to COW and prep:
<https://github.com/GW-datasci/26-spring-LUTZ-H/commit/cd598f2eb196b0397b64ca503263d569025727f3>
2. Prepped for merge (finding same cols):
<https://github.com/GW-datasci/26-spring-LUTZ-H/commit/38fafb30eeab429117f4df4f756011628e4f22af>